Thus it was that, once again, Salim's grandmother saved the prince from his father's wrath. On 29 August 1604, Hamida Banu Begum, Humayun's reluctant bride, who glowed with divine light during her pregnancy, and must have glowed as much with pride at her son's remarkable life, died in bed, unconscious.

Akbar shaved every last bit of hair on his head and face, removed his turban and 'donned the garb of woe'.[17] That very evening, however, he ordered that the rest of his court might remove their mourning clothes. It was Dussehra the next day, and Akbar didn't want to stop the celebrations. What difference would it make if his court continued to mourn, anyway? Akbar had lost one parent when he was a boy, the other, now, in his old age; and no matter who joined him to grieve his mother's death, Akbar would be alone.

Salim joined him.

It may be that the prince understood his father's loss and shared his grief for the woman who had loved them both so deeply; and it may be, too, that Hamida had given him one last opportunity to make amends – or even, more bluntly, to get on Akbar's right side. Later on, he would write that it was 'through that very act I became emperor'.[18] Salim abandoned his rebel throne in Allahabad and came to Agra with condolences.

Akbar greeted the prince warmly in public, but afterwards, in private, the dam of his anger burst and overflowed. Akbar may have hit Salim, he certainly yelled at him, while the prince stood meek, head bowed. For some days, Akbar even had the prince locked up in a makeshift rehabilitation programme, to wean him off alcohol, until Salim's sisters pleaded for him and he was let out.

Akbar may have been furious with Salim, but he was 'especially hopeless about Prince Daniyal'.[19]

It was soon after news of Abul Fazl's death that word arrived of Daniyal drinking again. Ever since, panicked, it appears, at the thought of losing another son to alcohol, Akbar had sent scolding letters and emissaries to Burhanpur, one after another – including a doctor and a childhood nurse 'not afraid to speak strongly' to the prince – by turns denouncing his 'perverted career', pleading with him to have pity on his own life and come home. But Daniyal would not return.[20]